

CRITICAL THINKING with Dr Sam:

Course plan for Summer Holiday, 2026

Overview:

These classes are designed with two main purposes.

- 1) To prepare students for school interviews, where they are often asked to discuss a topic which falls under what we study in Critical Thinking. The aim is to teach them how to approach difficult or unusual questions, where the answer might not be obvious or, more likely, where there is more than one possible answer. The focus here is as much on their ability to articulate themselves in speech as it is on their ability to write.
- 2) To demonstrate to students how, in approaching complex questions, uncertainty and scepticism play an important role. Students at this age are often unused to the idea that more than one thing can be 'correct'. However in their further studies, and especially if they go on to take scholarship exams, this idea will be crucially important. In these classes I teach skills that enable them to take that new approach confidently.

Breakdown of skills:

These skills this course teaches include but are not limited to:

- Logical reasoning. (How to build an argument that's logically sound.)
- Arguing with words. (How to make your arguments sound convincing.)
- Reacting to current affairs (that is, how to speak confidently and with relevant contextual knowledge.)
- Responding intelligently to images (paintings, photographs etc.)

My approach:

Each class has a particular focus. They are chosen carefully to facilitate the teaching of some aspects of the skills mentioned above. The classes will involve a combination of group discussion and individual work, whereby the latter allows students to focus on their individual arguments and how to express them. Below is a breakdown of how each class works.

The Structure of Each Class

Each class begins with a thought experiment: a hypothetical situation that raises a philosophical question. These will largely be drawn from *The Pig that Wants to Be Eaten: And 99 Other Thought Experiments*, by Julian Baginni. One of its experiments, for instance, asks: 'If a machine

destroyed you here and built an exact copy of you on Mars, would the person who woke up on Mars be you?’ The thought experiment sets the theme for the rest of the lesson.

From there we turn to one or two further materials, chosen to draw out the same theme from another direction. Sometimes this will be an image. It won’t always be a painting; it might be a sculpture, a political cartoon, an architectural drawing, or even a short film, which we practise responding to in words. Sometimes it will be a news story; before such lessons I will circulate a short article, and we will start simply before drawing out the more complex issues it raises. A recent discussion, for example, began with an article about an octopus that had broken out of its aquarium overnight, and ended on the question of whether intelligence is something we ‘recognise’ or something we ‘measure’.

In this way each class is self-contained: a single theme, opened by a thought experiment and then explored through the kinds of image and current-affairs discussion the students most enjoy.

Length of course:

The course runs to twenty such classes across the summer holiday, each built around a single theme in the way described above.

Example: Summary of Materials for the First Lesson

To show how a class works in practice, here is an outline of the materials for the first lesson, on the theme of personal identity.

1. The Thought Experiment: The Teleporter

Imagine that travel between Earth and Mars is now done by teleporter. You step into a booth on Earth. The machine scans your body in perfect detail, recording the exact position of every cell, and then destroys it. A moment later, on Mars, an identical body is built from new material, arranged precisely as the scan recorded. The person who steps out has all your memories, your voice, and your habits, and believes without a flicker of doubt that they are you. The question is easy to ask and hard to answer: is the person on Mars really you, or someone new who only thinks they are?

*Based on the teletransporter thought experiment discussed by Julian Baggini in *The Pig that Wants to Be Eaten*, and first set out by the philosopher Derek Parfit.*

2. The Image: Rembrandt's Self-Portraits

Rembrandt painted and drew himself throughout his life, from a confident young man in the 1620s to a lined and weary figure in 1669, the year he died. Set side by side, the portraits show a face changing almost beyond recognition. Every cell of the painter's body was replaced many times over across those years, and yet we say without hesitation that it is one man, Rembrandt, in every picture.

3. The News Story: A New Face

Surgeons can now carry out full face transplants, giving a patient the facial features of a donor who has died. Recipients describe the strange experience of looking in the mirror and seeing neither quite their old self nor quite the donor. Stories of these operations raise, in a real and practical form, the same question as the teleporter: how much can change before a person stops being who they were?